The decision for war

From all accounts, China finally took a decision to go to war on 6 October. They attacked in strength in both the eastern and western sectors two weeks later. Four days into the war, Zhou offered Nehru a deal: in the western sector, both armies would pull back twenty kilometres from the Line of Actual Control as on 7 November 1959. China would then return to its positions north of the McMahon Line. This would be followed by a meeting of the two prime ministers. When Delhi rejected the proposal, China resumed operations on 16 November. With Indian defences crumbling, China abruptly stopped its advance on 21 November and started to pull back to positions north of the McMahon Line. The war, of eleven days of actual fighting, was over. It remains India's shortest war.

Why in the end did China attack? The best account of Chinese decision-making is Garver's, which is based on China's official histories, informed accounts by former officials, and academic writings. In it, he argues that Mao and his senior advisers were convinced that India was destabilizing Tibet and wanted to turn it into an independent buffer zone; that India in the end did not want to negotiate any or all parts of the border sincerely and was not open to a political resolution (that is, the swap); and that the Forward Policy was militarily provocative and dangerous for China. While there may have been other motives as well – and Garver suggests that Chinese discourse on the necessity of war also refers to relations with Moscow and Washington – Tibet, the border stalemate, and the Forward Policy were central.

At the heart of it all was not territory itself. Rather, it was the significance of territory, particularly in the western sector, for Chinese control over Tibet. Given Beijing's assessment of Indian behaviour on Tibet, the border negotiations, and Indian military moves, it decided that Delhi needed to be administered a painful shock. A limited Chinese attack would be fruitless: defeating a weak Indian force in the west would fail to make the strategic point. Mao insisted on a large-scale attack all along the border but aimed particularly at India's military strength, which was in the